

- RAG Learning

1.8 Political Parties

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 1 (Government and Politics of the UK)

The specification requires you to study the **origins, ideas and development** of the Conservative, Labour and Liberal Democrat parties, how these shaped their current policies, and their structures and functions — along with party funding, minor parties and the nature of the UK party system.

Political party — an organised group that seeks to win political office in order to implement its programme, contesting elections under a common label. This distinguishes parties from pressure groups, which seek to *influence* whoever holds office rather than to hold it themselves.

1. Functions of parties

- **Representation** — aggregating and articulating the interests of sections of society.
- **Participation and recruitment** — a route into political activity; selecting candidates for office.
- **Policy formulation** — developing programmes presented to voters in a manifesto.
- **Providing government and opposition** — the governing team and the alternative.
- **Political education** — informing and structuring public debate.

2. The Conservative Party

Origins and traditions

Descended from the Tories; the modern party dates from the 1830s. Two dominant traditions:

One Nation

New Right (Thatcherism)

Paternalism and social obligation — Disraeli's "two nations" warning that a gulf between rich and poor threatens stability	Neo-liberalism: free markets, privatisation, deregulation, lower direct taxation, control of inflation, restriction of union power
Acceptance of state intervention and the welfare state	Neo-conservatism: strong state on law and order, traditional morality, national sovereignty, the traditional family
Pragmatism and gradual reform to preserve stability	Welfare dependency held to undermine self-reliance
Post-war consensus Conservatives; Macmillan; Cameron's early social liberalism	Thatcher; the 1980s privatisation programme; right-to-buy

Development

- **1945–79:** acceptance of the post-war settlement — the mixed economy, full employment, the NHS.
- **1979–90:** Thatcherism — privatisation of British Telecom and British Gas, right-to-buy, trade union legislation, reductions in the top rate of income tax.
- **1990s:** Major's government split by Europe, particularly over Maastricht.
- **2005–16:** Cameron's modernisation — social liberalism (same-sex marriage) combined with austerity after 2010.
- **2016–:** reshaped by Brexit; a new electoral coalition in 2019 built on Leave-voting former Labour seats; internal division over the size of the state.

3. The Labour Party

Origins

Founded in **1900** out of the trade union movement and socialist societies, to secure parliamentary representation for working people. The union link remains a defining structural feature — and a recurring source of controversy over funding and influence.

Old Labour and New Labour

Old Labour (social democracy)	New Labour (the Third Way)
Common ownership — the original Clause IV	Clause IV revised in 1995 , abandoning common ownership and endorsing a dynamic market economy
Nationalisation; a large public sector	Accepted privatisation and Conservative trade union legislation
Redistribution through progressive income tax	Redistribution through tax credits and the minimum wage, not higher income tax rates
Strong union influence	Power centralised around the leadership; union influence reduced
Equality of outcome	Equality of opportunity; "opportunity and responsibility"

Development since 2010: Miliband moved partly away from New Labour; Corbyn (2015–20) proposed extensive renationalisation and higher taxation, marking sharp ideological divergence from the Conservatives; Starmer moved back towards the centre.

Exam Tip: The Clause IV revision of 1995 is the single most useful example in this topic. It works as evidence for *ideological change*, for *leadership power over the party*, and for the *convergence thesis* — three different essay questions from one fact.

4. The Liberal Democrats

- Formed in **1988** by the merger of the Liberal Party and the Social Democratic Party (itself a 1981 breakaway from Labour).
- **Ideas:** constitutional reform (electoral reform, a codified constitution, Lords reform), civil liberties, environmentalism, internationalism and pro-Europeanism, decentralisation.
- Internal tension between **classical liberal** (economic, market-oriented) and **social liberal** (welfare-oriented) wings.

- **2010–15 coalition:** delivered a referendum on AV (lost) and a rise in the income tax threshold, but the tuition fees reversal was electorally catastrophic — the party fell from 57 seats to 8 in 2015.
- A cautionary case study in what FPTP and coalition do to the third party.

5. Party structure and internal democracy

Leadership selection

- **Labour:** one member one vote among members and affiliated supporters. The registered-supporters route (£3 in 2015) was abolished in 2021, when the threshold for nominations was also raised to 20 per cent of Labour MPs. The old rules produced Corbyn in 2015 despite limited support among Labour MPs; the 2021 changes were a direct response.
- **Conservative:** MPs shortlist two candidates; the membership chooses between them. Produced Truss in 2022 against the parliamentary party's preference.

Exam Tip: The examinable tension: party members are far more **ideologically committed** than the general electorate. Member-led selection enhances internal democracy but can produce leaders who command neither their parliamentary party nor broad public support — which is why both parties have repeatedly revisited these rules.

Candidate selection and policy

- Local party members select parliamentary candidates, under national rules and approved lists — so central machines retain significant control.
- Conference is formally significant for Labour but has in practice been managed by leaderships; New Labour in particular reduced the influence of both conference and the unions.

6. Party funding

Sources

- Membership subscriptions and small donations.
- Large donations from individuals and companies (Conservative) and affiliated trade unions (Labour).
- Limited public funding: **Short Money** (Commons opposition parties) and **Cranborne Money** (Lords), plus policy development grants.
- All donations above a threshold must be declared to the Electoral Commission; statutory limits apply to campaign spending.

For state funding	Against state funding
Reduces dependence on a small number of large donors, and the perception that access and honours can be bought	Taxpayers would fund parties they oppose
Fairer competition — allocation by votes received would match resources to demonstrated support	Could entrench existing parties against new entrants
Parties perform genuine public functions, as Short Money already partly recognises	Removes the incentive to build and maintain a mass membership
Frees parties to develop policy rather than fundraise	Hard to design a formula all parties would accept

7. Minor parties and the party system

Why minor parties struggle — and still matter

- **FPTP** penalises dispersed support: UKIP's 3.9 million votes produced one seat in 2015.
- But **concentrated** support succeeds: the SNP converted ~1.5 million votes into 56 seats the same year.
- Minor parties shape the agenda even without seats — UKIP's electoral pressure was central to the calling of the EU referendum.
- Proportional systems in the devolved nations give them a genuine platform.

- **2024** — the strongest evidence yet of fragmentation: Reform UK won 14.3 per cent (≈ 4.1 million votes) but 5 seats; the Liberal Democrats won 72 seats on 12.2 per cent; the Greens won 4; the SNP collapsed to 9; Labour won 411 seats on 33.7 per cent; the combined Conservative and Labour vote share fell to about 57 per cent.

Other parties

- **SNP** — in government at Holyrood since 2007; surged after the 2014 referendum to win 56 of 59 Scottish seats in 2015, then fell to 9 in 2024. Still the largest party at Holyrood after May 2026 (58 seats), governing as a minority under John Swinney.
- **Plaid Cymru** — 4 MPs in 2024; long a party of opposition in the Senedd (and briefly in coalition with Labour, 2007–11), it became the largest party in May 2026 with 43 of 96 seats, and Rhun ap Iorwerth became First Minister.
- **Northern Ireland** — a separate party system in which the main GB parties barely compete. The DUP propped up May's minority government through a confidence-and-supply deal (2017–19); Sinn Féin became the largest party at Stormont in 2022, but its MPs do not take their Westminster seats.
- **Greens and Reform UK** — the Greens won 4 seats in 2024 (their best result); Reform UK, UKIP's successor, won 5 seats on 14.3 per cent and came second in Wales in 2026 with 34 Senedd seats.

What kind of party system?

The honest answer is that it depends on what you measure and where you look.

- **Two-party** at Westminster by *seats* — Conservative and Labour have alternated in government throughout the post-war period.
- **Multi-party** by *votes* — the two main parties' combined share has fallen well below post-war levels, to about 57 per cent in 2024.
- **Multi-party** in the devolved nations under proportional systems.
- **Dominant-party** in particular periods — 1979–97 and 2010–24 — though that describes a phase rather than a structural feature.

8. Convergence and divergence

Evidence of convergence	Evidence of divergence
New Labour accepted privatisation, market mechanisms and Conservative spending limits	Post-2015: Corbyn proposed extensive renationalisation while the Conservatives pursued a hard Brexit
Cameron's Conservatives accepted NHS spending and social liberalism	Sharp disagreement on taxation, public ownership and the size of the state
Both competing for the median voter under FPTP — the "catch-all party" thesis	Brexit cut <i>across</i> parties rather than along them, fracturing both

The defensible conclusion is that convergence was a **phase** rather than a permanent condition, and that the underlying problem voters identify may be trust rather than lack of choice.

Key terms

Term	Definition
One Nation conservatism	Paternalistic tradition accepting intervention and welfare to preserve social cohesion
Thatcherism / New Right	Neo-liberal economics combined with neo-conservative social and national authority
Clause IV	Labour's original commitment to common ownership, revised in 1995
Third Way	New Labour's attempt to transcend free-market capitalism and state socialism
Faction	An organised internal grouping within a party (e.g. the European Research Group)
Catch-all party	A party broadening its appeal towards the centre, diluting ideological distinctiveness

Short Money	Public funding for opposition parties' parliamentary work in the Commons
Dealignment	Weakening of habitual class-based or partisan loyalties
Dominant-party system	One party winning repeatedly while the opposition fails to mount a credible challenge

Essential examples

- **Clause IV revision, 1995** — ideological change and leadership power.
- **1980s privatisations** — British Telecom, British Gas; right-to-buy.
- **2010–15 coalition** — Lib Dem tuition fees reversal; 57 seats to 8 in 2015.
- **Corbyn 2015** and **Truss 2022** — member-led selection against the parliamentary party's preference.
- **UKIP 2015** — 3.9m votes, one seat, decisive agenda influence.
- **Reform UK 2024** — 14.3% ($\approx$ 4.1m votes), five seats; dispersed support punished again.
- **SNP 2015** — 1.5m votes, 56 seats; concentration beats volume under FPTP.